

AN ACCUSATION CANNOT BE REPEATED

GRATIAN'S *DECRETUM*
(MID-12TH CENTURY)



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Canon law

BEFORE

325 Emperor Constantine convenes the first major council of the Christian Church at Nicaea (now Iznik, in Turkey).

380 Theodosius I issues the Edict of Thessalonica, making Christianity the state religion of the Roman Empire.

529 Emperor Justinian publishes his *Code*, an important source of canon law.

1100 Flemish priest Alger of Liège publishes the *Liber de misericordia et justitia* (*Book of Mercy and Justice*), from which Gratian borrows texts.

AFTER

1234 The *Liber extra* is published under the authority of Pope Gregory IX.

1917 The publication of a new code of canon law finally replaces Gratian's *Decretum*.

As the Christian Church grew in strength during its first centuries, and particularly after it emerged under Emperor Constantine from the shadows of persecution in 313 CE, it needed a law to govern it. The relatively small number of rules that could be derived from the New Testament had to be supplemented with a more detailed framework. This was required to govern both the behavior of the Church hierarchy itself and those areas such as